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84-355: Democracy's Data

31 October 2025

Immigrant Representation in Elections

The immigration process to enter America has become a widely controversial national discussion. Many immigrants face discrimination despite representing 13.9% of the American population.[1] With the Trump administration, immigrants have become critically aware of their rights–or lack thereof–in the United States. Federal crackdown on the laws surrounding immigration has set the topic on the hot seat of national coverage and what started as a ballot issue has developed into a crucial question of mortality. An NPR article reports, "...at least 20 people have died in ICE custody so far this year…[ICE] is also holding nearly 60,000 people in immigration detention, the highest number in several years".[2] This alarming rise in mistreatment against immigrants calls for decisive action in office, which can only be initiated by the people and, most importantly, the ballots. Within the last 10 years, citizens of the United States of America who were foreign-raised seem to have been voting consistently less than citizens raised natively. Additionally, out of the citizens who have voted, less foreign-raised citizens have voted for Republican candidates compared to that of native-raised citizens. This suggests an underrepresentation of immigrant citizens in America who may be withholding key votes that would be influential to the state of national protocol.

Immigrants are more likely to not feel belonging to the country where they live, and therefore often do not feel the need to participate in the politics of that nation. However, understanding the effects on immigrant voting behavior matters because without their voices, especially in a nation that is so diverse, the true population is not represented. Data can help shed light on the evolving role of immigrants in shaping the U.S. electorate and democratic process. As the immigrant population continues to grow, their political behavior will be of interest for policymakers, political parties, and advocacy groups seeking to represent a more diverse America. The ANES data not only help us measure engagement but also highlight barriers such as citizenship access, language obstacles, and political alienation. The ANES data show that immigrant voting habits evolve and ultimately shape the broader electorate in increasingly effective ways. Recognising that shift helps us understand not just how immigrants will vote tomorrow, but how they will change American elections and policy in the coming decades.

Dating back to 1948, the ANES survey provides one of the most comprehensive and longitudinal datasets on political attitudes and voting behaviors in the United States. Using ANES data, we can explore how the voting habits–that is, the turnout and preference–of immigrant voters have shifted across the years and how national or global policy and current events shape these trends. Changes in turnout and party preference over time reveal the political effects of landmark legislation, like the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 or the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) policy. One NPR interview illustrates the tenuous nature

1. Census Data, U.S. Gov, "New Report on the Nation's Foreign-Born Population." April 9, 2024. https://www.census.gov/newsroom/press-releases/2024/foreign-born-population.html.
2. Bustillo & Mukherjee, NPR, "It's the deadliest year for people in ICE custody in decades; next year could be worse." October 23, 2025. https://www.npr.org/2025/10/23/nx-s1-5538090/ice-detention-custody-immigration-arrest-enforcement-dhs-trump.

of the law. Josue Rodriguez, a recipient of DACA, speaks on the impacts an overruling of DACA would have on his life: "I could become undocumented tomorrow if the court goes against it".[3] The impact of law on the voting behavior of citizens can uncover what truly motivates immigrant voters and what could increase voter turnout in this particular group of people.

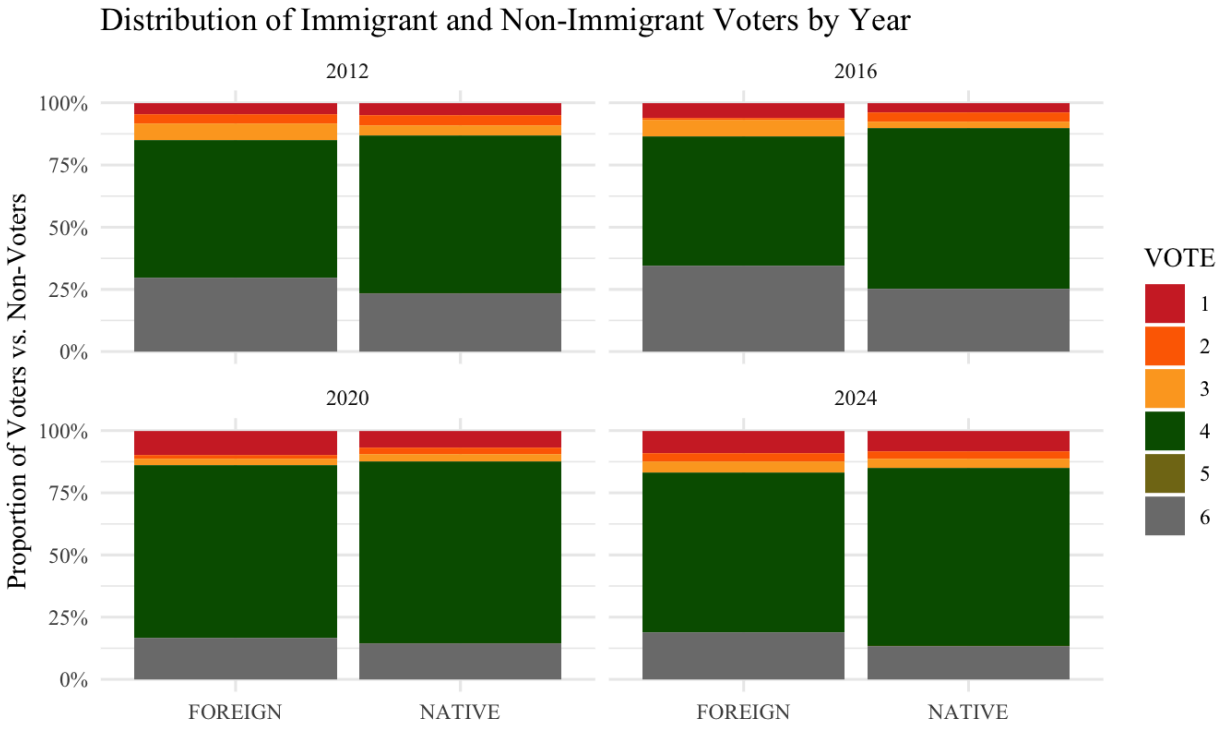


Figure 1. The proportional bar chart shows the distribution of U.S. citizens who did and did not vote, self-reported. Data collected from the past 4 ANES reports (https://electionstudies.org/data-center/) and was grouped by where the participant grew up in Rstudio. The key on the right is: 1) did not vote, 2) thought about it but did not vote, 3) usually will vote but did not vote this time, 4) voted, 5) refused to answer the question, and 6) n/a. The official statements selected on the survey are pictured to the right.

The data in Figure 1 is from the four most recent ANES surveys, comparing the responses to questions: "Where did R grow up" (2024 - V241529, 2020 - V201575, 2016 - V161330, 2012 - dem3_grewup) and "Which statement best describes whether or not R voted in the November election" (2024 - V242065, 2020 - V202066, 2016 - V162031, 2012 - postvote_rvote). The data was then plotted using the R library ggplot2. This graph demonstrates a slight difference in voter turnout of foreign-raised citizens compared to native-raised citizens. The survey participants in 2012 and 2016 respectively. Although the gap lessens in 2020, there is more non-voting recorded in 2020 and less survey error, so it may be that more participants were able to report their actions than in the first two cases rather than a true shift in voting behavior. Despite possible errors, it remains reasonable that there is a statistically-significant gap in turnout between groups and the differences are not a result of random chance from the survey. Additionally, less foreign-raised voters selected option three in 2020, meaning they did not report

3. Moore & Ahmad, NPR, "How growing up in the U.S. immigration system shapes how these young Americans vote." August 18, 2024. https://www.npr.org/2024/08/16/nx-s1-5057589/young-voters-immigration-daca-dreamers-first-generation-gen-z-millennial.

4. Maeve Reston, CNN, "How Trump's deportation plan failed 62 years ago." January 19, 2016. https://www.cnn.com/2016/01/19/politics/donald-trump-deportation-mexico-eisenhower/index.html.

themselves considering voting. This is concerning because this reflects a potentially growing sense of apathy within the immigrant community surrounding politics. More foreign-raised voters considered voting in 2024 than in 2020, but still less of them actually cast a ballot than non-immigrant voters. The graph suggests an underlying imbalance in the representation of citizens in America.

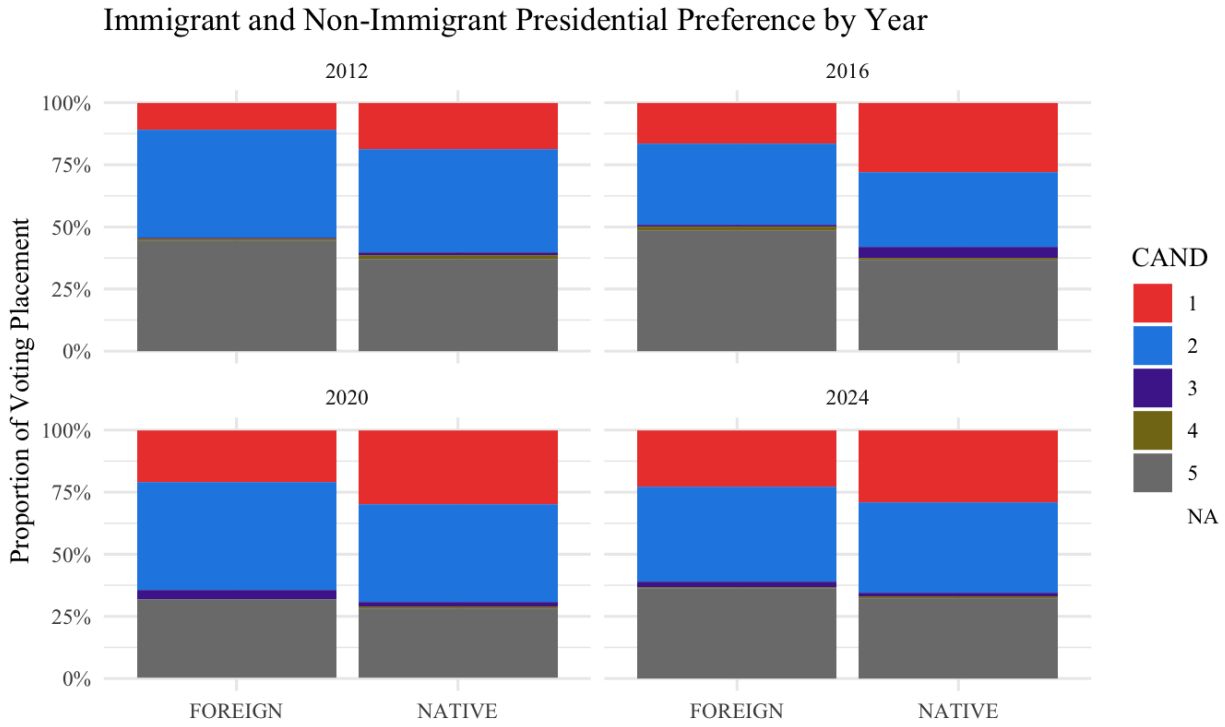


Figure 2. The figure shows proportionally how people voted in the last four presidential elections, grouped by the location in which people grew up. Graphic made in Rstudio. The key is coded as follows: 1) Republican, 2) Democratic, 3) Other, 4) Refused to answer the question, 5) N/A. The data was collected with the ANES survey.

The data in Figure 2 compares the responses to questions from the ANES survey: "Where did R grow up" and "For whom did R vote for President" (2024 - V242067 , 2020 - V202073 , 2016 - V162034a , 2012 - postvote_presvtwho). Out of those who did vote in the presidential election, the data shows that foreign-raised voters tended to vote Republican at lower rates than voters raised in America. Contrary to instinct, this is not produced by a higher rate of Democratic voting among foreign-raised citizens. In fact, in any of the last four presidential elections, there seems to be no difference in the proportion of foreign and natively raised voters who voted blue. Instead, the lower rates of red votes are accounted for in a larger proportion of N/A responses, meaning that either the survey participant was not asked the question or it was not applicable. This consistently larger proportion of foreign-raised American voters who are represented by an N/A in the dataset demonstrates the shadow that is being cast on immigrant citizens of this nation in what can be incredibly divisive to the state of the nation. It could be that more foreign-raised citizens had trouble recording their responses in the survey, possibly due to language barriers, and they were not asked the same questions as survey participants who had less barriers. It is more likely that less foreign-raised citizens voted in the last four presidential elections than

3. Moore & Ahmad, NPR, "How growing up in the U.S. immigration system shapes how these young Americans vote." August 18, 2024. https://www.npr.org/2024/08/16/nx-s1-5057589/young-voters-immigration-daca-dreamers-first-generation-gen-z-millennial.

4. Maeve Reston, CNN, "How Trump's deportation plan failed 62 years ago." January 19, 2016. https://www.cnn.com/2016/01/19/politics/donald-trump-deportation-mexico-eisenhower/index.html.

native-raised citizens due to the findings of the previous chart. Either way, it is clear that immigrants are being under-representated in our nation and need to exercise their rights as legal citizens of America.

Immigration and naturalization has been written into our constitution as a national concern. There are and has always been many differing opinions on the preferred policies surrounding who to accept as citizens of the USA, but no opinion can justify the brutal and inhumane treatment that occurs in detention camps, mandated by our own government. Historically, immigrants from certain regions of the world have been lawfully excluded from naturalization and barred from entering the nation. President Trump in 2015 pushed for harsher immigration laws, drawing inspiration from an aggressive federal roundup from the Eisenhower administration called "Operation Wetback".[4] The same sentiment echoes today through ICE raids and detainment of citizens: certain groups of people are not welcome in America. Despite hostility, it is the responsibility of those affected to exercise their voice and put their hand on the scale. With all the injustice against immigrants, it is all the more surprising to see that they are voting at lower rates than American-born citizens. There might be a need for action to ensure that those who are being mistreated have an equal opportunity to advocate for themselves and their loved ones.

Over four elections, a trend can be seen in voting behavior among citizens raised in foreign countries when compared to those who were raised natively. These citizens are voting at lower rates and are less likely to cast a vote towards the Republican candidate for president. Within the complicated context of today's political landscape, this disparity in representation calls for action among policymakers in office and among the underrepresented. Americans born outside the country deserve to be equal participants in our democracy as much as anyone, especially in laws that affect them personally. Moving forward, the issue of immigration in America would be better understood and handled by all parties involved with the encouragement of open and empathetic discussion and the inclusion of more diverse and representative participants in that discussion.

3. Moore & Ahmad, NPR, "How growing up in the U.S. immigration system shapes how these young Americans vote." August 18, 2024. https://www.npr.org/2024/08/16/nx-s1-5057589/young-voters-immigration-daca-dreamers-first-generation-gen-z-millennial.

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